

PART 4 OF 5. THE PART THAT DECIDES WHETHER PEOPLE HATE THIS.

Send it where people already are

Here is the thing nobody building an internal tool wants to hear. The engineering is not what makes this work or fail. The message is.

The same three facts, sent to a group channel, are a public correction. Sent as a direct message, they are a reminder. Written with any urgency in them, they are nagging. Written flat and factual, with something specific to do, they are help.

I learned this by getting it wrong. This part is the wording, the destination and the schedule, and it is worth more attention than the code.

1 Send it to the person, never to the channel

A message in a shared channel is visible to everybody the person works with and everybody they report to. Even a completely neutral sentence becomes a public statement about them, in front of an audience, on a permanent record.

Direct message, always. Same facts, one recipient, no audience.

EXAMPLE

If you genuinely need a group view, that is a dashboard the team looks at together, not a message pointed at one person in front of everybody.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the fastest way to make people hate a tool is to make it feel like surveillance. Private is most of what makes it acceptable.

2 Write it flat, and always give them something to do

Four things. What the item is. What the situation is. One question. An easy way out.

No urgency words. No exclamation marks. No "just checking in", which everybody knows is not just checking in. And nothing about their history, because a tool that keeps score is a tool people learn to avoid.

EXAMPLE

Hey, item 4471 was due Tuesday and it is still in development. Anything you need from me, or should we move the date?

WHY THIS MATTERS: the message has to be something a reasonable person can read on their phone, answer in eight words, and forget about. Anything longer gets saved for later, and later is never.

3 Let them answer where they already are

The reason updates never happen is not laziness. It is that updating means opening another system, finding the item, finding the right field and typing into a box designed for somebody else.

Take that away. Let them reply to your message, in the tool they are already in, in one line. Then you move it to wherever the record lives.

EXAMPLE

My version sends a message where people already talk, they reply to it, and their reply gets copied to the work item. They never open the tracker at all.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you are not trying to change anybody's behavior, which is very hard. You are removing four steps from something they were already willing to do, which is easy.

4 Copy their words exactly, and say where it came from

If you move somebody's reply into a system of record, use their words. Do not summarize. Do not tidy it up. Do not turn "should be fine" into "on track", because those are different statements and the second one is now attached to their name.

Say who said it and when, and make it obvious it was relayed rather than written by you.

EXAMPLE

Reported by the item owner, Tuesday, relayed from chat. Then their sentence, exactly as they typed it.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the moment a person finds a status with their name on it that they did not say in those words, you have lost them and everybody they tell.

5 One item per message, then cap how many somebody gets

This is the part I got wrong first, and the reason is worth understanding before you build.

If somebody replies to your message, the reply carries a pointer back to the exact message it answers. That pointer is what tells you which item they meant. Put six items in one message and that pointer becomes useless, because "done" could refer to any of them. So it is one item, one message, one thing to reply to.

That creates the obvious problem. Somebody with six late items would get six messages in one morning. So cap it. One message per person per day, and the rest wait until tomorrow. It is slower on purpose.

EXAMPLE

One run each weekday morning. If a person is due four nudges, they get one today and the other three over the following days, oldest first.

WHY THIS MATTERS: a correct update three days late is worth more than a wrong one today. The cap is what stops a well-behaved tool from turning into a pile of notifications nobody reads.

The parts that decide whether this works are all human. Private instead of public. Flat instead of urgent. Their words instead of yours. One item per message so a reply means something.

Pick a time that gives somebody a chance to act before anybody senior asks them about it. Early morning is good. Right before a review is not, because then it is a threat rather than a help. Predictability is what turns this into part of the furniture.

Part 5 is last: the rules I do not break, what happens when it breaks, and the second thing to build once the first one works.